Leaver process: returning equipment and account removal

Article KB0010091 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: General | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS laptops (MacBook Pro/Air on macOS 14/15), Mobile devices enrolled in Intune (iOS/Android), Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) user accounts, On-premises Active Directory accounts, Exchange Online mailboxes (50?GB + online archive), OneDrive for Business and SharePoint sites, Microsoft Teams, Palo Alto GlobalProtect VPN certificates, PaperCut secure print release

Summary

The leaver process ensures that when an employee departs Acme Global, all company-issued equipment is returned and all digital accounts are disabled or removed in a timely and secure manner. It protects corporate data, prevents unauthorized access, and satisfies compliance requirements. Both the departing employee and the IT Service Desk have defined steps to complete the process.

Symptoms

- Received a formal exit notification from manager or HR indicating the last working day
- User still able to log into corporate systems after the exit date
- Company-issued laptop, phone, badge, or other equipment not yet returned to IT

Common causes

- Employee resignation or voluntary termination
- Involuntary termination or dismissal
- End of fixed-term contract, internship, or temporary assignment
- Internal transfer requiring de-provisioning of the old account and creation of a new one

Overview

When an employee leaves Acme Global, the goal is to retrieve all physical assets and disable or delete all associated digital identities within the agreed service-level windows. The process is coordinated between the employee's manager, HR, the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team, and the Service Desk. Timely completion reduces risk of data leakage and helps meet P1-P4 resolution targets for any related incidents.

Prerequisites

Before starting the leaver workflow, ensure the following are in place: a completed HR exit form or manager-approved exit ticket in the Service Desk portal, confirmation of the employee's last working day, and a list of all assigned assets (laptop, monitor, mobile device, accessories, ID badge, VPN token). The employee should have backed up any personal data from OneDrive or local drives to an approved location, as corporate data will be retained per policy.

Self-Help Procedure for Departing Employee

Follow these steps to return equipment and initiate account removal. This procedure can be performed by the employee themselves after receiving the exit notice.

1. Notify your manager and HR of your intended last day and obtain an exit ticket number from the Service Desk portal (https://it.acme.example).
2. Back up any personal files from your OneDrive, local desktop, or external drives to a personal cloud storage or USB drive; corporate data will be retained by IT.
3. Power off your laptop, disconnect all peripherals, and place the device, charger, and any accessories in the designated IT return box located at your office's reception or ship them via the prepaid label provided in the exit email.
4. Return your mobile phone, SIM card, and any VPN hardware tokens to the same return location.
5. Visit the self-service password reset portal (https://passwordreset.acme.example) and change your password to a temporary value; this triggers the lockout process after 5 failed attempts if you attempt to log in again.
6. If you have a GlobalProtect VPN certificate installed, open the GlobalProtect client, select 'Disconnect', then uninstall the client from your device.
7. Finally, confirm with the Service Desk via Teams channel "IT Help" or phone extension 4357 that all items have been received and request confirmation that your Entra ID and on-prem AD accounts have been disabled.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

Agents in the Identity & Access Management group (with L1 escalation path) execute the following steps once the employee's exit ticket is received and equipment is returned.

1. Create or locate the Service Desk ticket tagged with the employee's ID and exit date; set priority to P2 (High) with a target resolution of 8?hours.
2. Verify receipt of all listed assets (laptop, mobile, badge, VPN token) by checking the asset return log or receiving confirmation from the employee's manager.
3. In Microsoft Entra ID, locate the user account, block sign-in, and initiate a license removal; then schedule the account for deletion after 30?days (or immediate deletion if required by policy).
4. Sync the change to on-premises Active Directory via Azure AD Connect; disable the AD account and remove from any distribution lists or security groups.
5. Revoke the Exchange Online mailbox, place it on a retention hold per policy, and remove any SharePoint or OneDrive permissions; retain the data per the retention schedule.
6. Revoke the GlobalProtect VPN certificate from the Palo Alto firewall and notify the networking team if any issues arise.
7. Disable PaperCut printing rights for the user and collect any pending print jobs.
8. Add a final comment to the ticket confirming completion, attach screenshots of the disabled accounts, and resolve the ticket.

Verification and Closure

After the above steps are completed, both the employee and the Service Desk should verify that access has been terminated and that all assets are accounted for. Any discrepancies must be reported immediately.

1. Attempt to log in with the employee's credentials; the login should fail with an account-disabled message.
2. Check the Azure AD sign-in logs for the user to confirm no successful authentications after the exit timestamp.
3. Confirm that the laptop's BitLocker recovery key remains stored in Intune and that the device shows as 'compliant' or 'retired' in the device inventory.
4. Ensure the employee's mailbox shows as 'soft-deleted' or 'inactive' in the Exchange admin center and that OneDrive shows no active sync clients.
5. Close the Service Desk ticket only after verification succeeds and record the actual closure time for SLA reporting.

When to escalate

If the employee's Entra ID or AD account remains active after the agent procedure, or if equipment is missing beyond 24?hours of the expected return date, escalate immediately to the Identity & Access Management team lead (via Teams channel "IAM-Escalations") and copy the Security Operations SOC. Include the employee's ID, ticket number, list of missing assets, and screenshots showing active login attempts. For P1 incidents (e.g., suspected data exfiltration), follow the 24x7 phone path (extension 4357) and notify the Security Operations group per the incident-response playbook.

Keywords: leaver, exit process, equipment return, account removal, Entra ID, Active Directory, GlobalProtect, BitLocker, FileVault, PaperCut, Service Desk, IAM, HR exit, last working day, account disabling, mailbox retention, VPN certificate revoke